not have our resilience will have no choice but to bend before a few power centres. Even between major powers, rules could prevent the instability that is in no one's interest. At the same time, there is a developing awareness that in domains like the digital one, rule-making can be used to freeze the leads of established players. Increasing capabilities, therefore, needs to be accompanied by bolder policymaking and building narratives.

Shaping opinions and conditioning thinking are integral aspects of political contestation. If the domain of information has assumed a higher profile now, it does not imply only recognition of its salience but also the availability of new tools. The anachronism of propaganda may have now yielded place to an industry driven by technology and data, but like many other practices in vogue, we should not forget that this too has its history.

Controlling the narrative is always a fight and technology has made it far more complex. Those responsible for law, order and security have to struggle with it every day. It can distort, motivate, alarm, confuse and mislead, sometimes all at the same time. But do not forget the impact of the routine: what we read, see and hear all the time. Think about it: these are also processes of acceptance or rejection at work. The forces that drive them often extend beyond nation-states and traditional definitions of power and influence. On occasion, they could root strongly for the status quo and be sensitive to departures from it. The vehement opposition from select quarters to the change in respect of Article 370 is a case to point. But they may equally make the case for radicalism, or perhaps even extremism in a more acceptable form. We see their hand at work as well when cross-border terrorism is depicted as just a more vigorous form of post-Partition differences.

In fact, the very image of nations is often moulded with an agenda in mind. Data protectionism is an argument used to trivialize digital delivery and justify data monetization. In the same vein, the concept of 'big emitters' seeks to evade historical responsibility. Either way, entrenched elites will monitor and resist the kind of rebalancing that gives emerging societies the confidence to define their own interests.

As with standards in the material field, rising powers typically face narrative challenges from the established views of early movers. In the world of ideas, they seek to define political correctness and make that universal. Often, external interests are strongly aligned with local elite with whom there is a mutual understanding. Our own experience in recent years